

TRADE**B**BUILT

QUICK GUIDE

5 Things Every Contractor Should Have Under Control.

BETTER BUSINESSES
BUILT HERE.

PEOPLE

SYSTEMS

PROFIT

FREEDOM

Before we start

This isn't a textbook. Think of it more like sitting down over a cup of coffee with another contractor and talking through a few things that can make or break the business behind the work.

Good workmanship matters. But good workmanship on its own doesn't guarantee a good business. You can be busy, have happy clients and still lose money because the quote was wrong, extras were absorbed, payment stages were weak or you simply never checked what the job actually made.

Here are five fundamentals worth getting under control.

Your Health Check helps show where I should look first. This guide gives you a few practical principles you can start thinking about immediately.

01

Know what the job actually made

Turnover is not profit. A job can look good because money came into the account, but that doesn't tell you what you made.

Once the job is complete, compare the selling price against the real labour, materials, subcontractors, transport, hire, overhead exposure, extras and other costs that belonged to that job.

Simple rule: don't judge a job by whether there is money left in the bank. Close the job properly and find out what it actually made.

If you don't know what past jobs made, it becomes very difficult to price the next one intelligently.

02

Stop giving away extras

A small extra here. A quick change there. The client asks while you're already on site, so you just get it done. Individually they don't feel serious. Across a project they can quietly eat your profit.

When the scope changes, stop and make the commercial side clear before the extra work starts: what changed, what it costs and whether the client has approved it.

Get it in writing. A WhatsApp or email confirmation is better than relying on memory and goodwill.

You are not being difficult by charging for additional work. You are protecting the agreement you originally priced.

03

Don't fund the client's project

Deposits and progress payments are not just about getting paid. They are there to keep the project's cash requirements aligned with the work being done.

If you're paying wages, buying materials and carrying project costs long before the client pays you, your business is financing their project.

Build payment stages around exposure. As the project commits your cash, the client's payments should keep pace.

A profitable job can still create serious cash-flow pressure when the payment structure is wrong.

04

Get the job clear before you start

Many expensive problems begin before anyone picks up a tool. The quote says one thing, the client assumes another, and halfway through the job everyone remembers the conversation differently.

Make the important things clear: scope, inclusions, exclusions, responsibilities, payment terms, materials, timing, variations and approvals.

A good quote is more than a price. It is the commercial agreement for how the job is supposed to work.

The clearer the job is at the beginning, the easier it is to manage changes, expectations and money later.

05

Communication is part of the job

Clients don't only judge the finished work. They judge what it feels like to have you working in their home, business or project.

Tell them what is happening. Tell them what comes next. If something changes or goes wrong, tell them early rather than waiting for them to discover it.

Silence creates uncertainty. Clear communication builds trust - especially when the job doesn't go perfectly.

Professional communication also makes it easier to resolve problems, get approvals, collect payment and earn reviews and referrals.

The bigger point

The goal isn't to turn your contracting business into a complicated corporate machine. It is to get the basics under enough control that good work actually produces a good business.

Know what jobs make. Protect the scope. Charge for changes. Structure payments properly. Communicate well.

Then build the business you actually want - whether that's a strong owner-led specialist business, a small team, or something that can eventually operate without you on every job.

Your Health Check is only the first look.

I will personally review your answers and get back to you with the areas I believe are worth looking at first. The Health Check is a starting point for investigation, not a generic automated diagnosis.

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